of Shiva. Whatever his failings, Ravana and his southern kingdom are categorically within the Indian civilizational milieu. Indeed, the Kanyakubja Brahmins of Vidisha claim Ravana as one of their own and still worship him! [3] The exchange of goods and ideas along the Southern Road, therefore, had linked the north and the south of India long before political unification under the Mauryans in the third century BC.

The Mahabharata is 100,000 verses long and said to the longest composition in the world. According to tradition, it was composed by the sage Vyas but it appears to have been expanded over the centuries. We know that a shorter version of the epic was definitely in existence by the fifth century BC but it probably reached its current form centuries later. It is the story of the bitter rivalry between cousins—the five Pandav brothers and the Kauravs—for control over the kingdom of Hasthinapur. They initially agree to divide the kingdom and the Pandavs build a new capital called Indraprastha. The new capital was so beautiful that the Kauravs were filled with envy. They challenged the Pandavs to a game of dice that is fixed by their maternal uncle Shakuni. The Pandavs gamble away their kingdom and are exiled for thirteen years. During this time the Pandavs wander across India. However, when they return after thirteen years, the Kauravs refuse to return the kingdom.

The dispute culminates in the great battle of Kurukshetra in which virtually all the kingdoms of India are said to have taken sides. Krishna, leader of the Yadav clan and king of Dwarka, sided with the Pandavs and played an important role. The Pandavs win the war but at great cost. The Kauravs and their allies are almost all annihilated. The last act of the battle takes place away from the main battlefield. Bhim, strongest of the Pandav brothers, kills Duryodhan, the leader of the Kauravs, in single combat on the banks of the Saraswati. By now it would have dwindled to a shadow of its former self—perhaps no more than a rain-fed seasonal river.

Many of the places mentioned in the Mahabharata are located around Delhi. For instance, Gurgaon, now a modern boom-town full of gleaming office-towers and shopping-malls, was a village that belonged to Dronacharya, the teacher who trained the cousins in martial arts. The name